means of the health of a tribe,' he said, 'if He made this servant, who sits upon a lofty seat of rule, a source of good, what is there to cause surprise?' The emperor was referring to a story from the time of his ancestor Chinghis Khan. The khan's army was in Georgia, and Georgia was overrun by a plague. 'On the first day there was fever. On the second the teeth loosened. On the third the cup of life became full.' Meanwhile, an old woman in the town was less concerned by the sickness than by the fear that she would not live to put henna on her daughter – that is, get her married. Sure enough, the old woman fell ill. On the second day, her teeth loosening, she began 'putting henna on her darling', wetting it with her spit. The next day, she prepared to die, but recovered instead. She had stumbled upon a cure for the plague – and a source of great profit for the precursors of the pharmaceutical industry. 'Henna became the value of pearls, and the merchants made great profits.'[19]

There was no such woman now to save Asirgarh. Some 25,000 people died of the sickness; and Asirgarh's generals, battling disease on the one hand and the psychological disadvantage of a fallen king on the other, could no longer hold out. Asirgarh fell. 'I myself sat at the gate,' writes Abul Fazl, 'and in four days 34,000 persons came out with their families and goods.'

Once again, a 'glorious victory adorned the face of fortune' – if, however, for the last time.[20]

~

Akbar had continued, throughout, to recite God's name. Ahmednagar had fallen a few months previously, soon after Chand Bibi – 'that choice lady', in Abul Fazl's admiring words – was murdered by her own insecure nobility. Now Asirgarh was Akbar's.

God had listened, as He always did. Or had He? Was it for military success, at all, that Akbar was praying?

It was during the siege of Asirgarh that news arrived of Salim's rebellion. The prince had made a failed attempt at raiding Agra's treasury, then sailed east, commandeered 30 lakh rupees from Bihar and installed himself on a throne in Allahabad. In two years, Akbar had lost two sons – one to alcohol, the other to mutiny. When, in February 1601, some two months after Asirgarh's fall, Daniyal arrived in Burhanpur with news of a moderately